BALLS OF FURY

SPORTS

India's Ultimate Table Tennis league is back after a hiatus of three years

In 2019, Diya Chitale was a 16-year-old junior table tennis player who stood in the stands of Thyagaraj Sports Complex in New Delhi to cheer the participants competing in Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT), India's premier league in the sport. Next year, she was looking forward to making her debut until a dreaded virus disrupted her dream. After a hiatus of three years, UTT is back (July 13-30), and Chitale, who was recently included in India's Asian Games squad, finally gets her shot at UTT playing for home team, U Mumba. The excitement in the 20-year-old paddler's voice is palpable. "It is a fun, fast and fan-friendly format. It is different from what we are used to playing," she says. "Every game matters and anything can happen. It's not like because you are a higher-ranked player you will win."

Most agree that since UTT's inaugural edition in 2017, table tennis in India has grown. Ten-time national champion and Asian Games and Commonwealth Games medallist Achanta Sharath Kamal, who will be in action for the Chennai Lions team, cites how India's team ranking improved in the aftermath of the league's launch in 2017—from 24 to nine by the end of it. "Twenty years ago, I went to Europe in search of such an opportunity where I could train and share space and get knowledge from foreign players. UTT gives all of that to youngsters," he says. "It has been one of the best talent scouts that we have had." Manav Thakkar and Sutirtha Mukherjee shone in earlier editions. The rookies to watch out for in the fourth edition include Chitale, Payas Jain and Ankur Bhattacharjee.

Apart from giving a platform to the next generation of Indian table tennis players, UTT also recruits foreign players and coaches. World #22



IN TOP FORM *(from far left)* Quadri Aruna, Sreeja Akula, Achanta Sharath Kamal and Diya Chitale at the UTT league

Photographs Courtesy: ULTIMATE TABLE TENNIS